

Area of Study 3C – Islam

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Islam as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about the issues of Philosophy of Religion, and issues of equality and social justice.

There are four sections: Islamic Beliefs, Philosophy of Religion, Living the Muslim Life and Equality.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Muslims today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how the Qur'an informs a Muslim's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Islam within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Islam with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.8)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.3)*

Students should recognise that Islam is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Islam and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Islam there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Islam in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Sunni and Shi'a traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The Six Beliefs of Islam: their nature, history and purpose, including Kitab al-iman 1:4; how they are understood and expressed in Sunni and Shi'a Muslim communities today; the importance of these principles for Muslims.
1.2	The Five Roots of 'Usul ad-Din in Shi'a Islam: Tawhid (oneness of Allah); 'Adl (Divine Justice); Nubuwwah (Prophethood); Imamah (Successors to Muhammad) and Mi'ad (The Day of Judgment and the Resurrection); the nature, history and purpose of the Five Roots with reference to their Qur'anic basis, including Surah 112 (the oneness of Allah); the importance of these principles for different Shi'a communities today, including Sevener and Twelver.
1.3	The nature of Allah: how the characteristics of Allah are shown in the Qur'an and why they are important; Tawhid (oneness), including Surah 16:35–36, immanence, transcendence, omnipotence, beneficence, mercy, fairness and justice, Adalat in Shi'a Islam.
1.4	Risalah: the nature and importance of prophethood for Muslims, including Surah 2:136; what the roles of prophets teach Muslims, exemplified in the lives of Adam, Ibrahim, Isma'il, Musa, Dawud, Isa, and Muhammad.
1.5	Muslim holy books (Kutub) – the nature, history, significance and purpose of Muslim holy books with reference to: the Qur'an; the Tawrat (Torah), including Surah 5:43–48; the Zabur (Psalms), including Surah 4:163–171; the Injil (Gospel), including Surah 57:27; and the Sahifah (Scrolls). Divergent Muslim views about the importance of the holy books in their lives today.
1.6	Malaikah: the nature and importance of angels for Muslims; how angels Jibril, Izra'il and Mika'il are shown in the Quran, including Surah 32:11 and 2:97–98, and their significance for Muslims today.
1.7	al-Qadr: the nature and importance of Predestination for Muslims; how al-Qadr and human freedom relates to the Day of Judgement, including reference to Sahih al-Bukhari 78:685; divergent understandings of predestination in Sunni and Shi'a Islam; the implications of belief in al-Qadr for Muslims today.
1.8*	Akhirah: Muslim teachings about life after death; the nature of judgement, paradise and hell; how they are shown in the Qur'an, including Surah 17:49–72; divergent ways in which Muslim teachings about life after death affect the life of a Muslim today.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Revelation as proof of the existence of Allah; the Qur'an as revelation; revelation as shown in the Qur'an as direct (Surah 34:46–50) or through a messenger; divergent understandings of what revelation shows about the nature of Allah for Muslims.
2.2	Visions as proof of the existence of Allah: the nature and importance of visions in Islam; Qur'anic examples of visions, including Surah 19:16–22; reasons why they might lead to belief in the existence of Allah, and Muslim responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that visions are hallucinations and provide no proof that Allah exists; divergent understandings of what visions show about the nature of Allah for Muslims, with reference to Sunni, Shi'a and Sufi Islam.
2.3	Miracles as proof of the existence of Allah: the nature and importance of miracles in Islam; the Qur'an as a miracle, including Surah 17:84–89; examples of miracles; reasons why they might lead to belief in the existence of Allah; Muslim responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that miracles can be scientifically explained and provide no proof that Allah exists; divergent understandings of what miracles show about the nature of Allah for Muslims.
2.4	Muslim attitudes towards religious experiences and their use as philosophical arguments for the existence of Allah: the nature of a religious experience; Surah 2:118; divergent understandings of the nature and importance of religious experiences in Islam, with reference to Sunni, Shi'a and Sufi Islam; Muslim responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments that religious experiences do not provide proof that Allah exists.
2.5	Design argument: the design argument and its use in Islam as a philosophical argument for the existence of Allah and what it shows about the nature of Allah; divergent understandings of the nature and importance of the design argument for the existence of Allah in Islam, including reference to Surah 2:164; Muslim responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the design argument as evidence for the existence of Allah.
2.6	Cosmological argument: the cosmological argument and its use in Islam as a philosophical argument for the existence of Allah, including reference to Surah 79:27–33 and kalam in the writings of Al-Ghazali, including <i>Kitab al-Iqtisad fil'Itiqad</i> ; what the cosmological argument shows about the nature of Allah; divergent understandings of the strengths and challenges of the cosmological argument in Islam; Muslim responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the cosmological argument as evidence for the existence of Allah.
2.7	Issues raised by existence of suffering and Allah as compassionate, including Surah 1: the problems the existence of suffering may raise for Muslims about the nature of Allah; how the problem and its basis as a philosophical argument may lead some people to reject belief in Allah or cause believers to question their belief.
2.8	The different practical and philosophical solutions offered to the problem of suffering and Allah as compassionate within Islam: Qur'anic, including Surah 2:151–177; theoretical and practical responses, including life as a test, prayer and charity; divergent understandings within Islam of their success in solving the problem.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	Ten Obligatory Acts of Shi'a Islam: their nature, history and purpose of the Ten Obligatory Acts; the diversity of practice and importance of Ten Obligatory Acts for Shi'a Muslims today; their basis in the Qur'an, including reference to Surah 9:71–73; divergent understandings of these principles within Sunni Islam, including links with the Five Pillars.
3.2	Shahadah as one of the Five Pillars: the nature, role and significance of Shahadah for Sunni and Shi'a Muslims, including reference to Surah 3:17–21; why reciting Shahadah is important for Muslims, and its place in Muslim practice today.
3.3*	Salah as one of the Five Pillars, including reference to Surah 15:98–99 and 29:45: the nature, history, significance and purpose of Salah for Sunni and Shi'a Muslims, including different ways of understanding them; how Salah is performed, including ablution, times, directions, movements and recitations, in the home and mosque and Jumma prayer.
3.4	Sawm as one of the Five Pillars: the nature, role, significance and purpose of fasting during Ramadan, including Surah 2:183–185; those who are excused from fasting and why. The significance of the Night of Power: the nature, history and purpose of the Night of Power; why Laylat al-Qadr is important for Muslims today.
3.5	Zakah as one of the Five Pillars and Khums: the nature, role, significance and purpose of Zakah and Khums, including Surah 9:58–60 and 8:36–42; why Zakah is important for Sunni Muslims; why Khums is important for Shi'a Muslims; the benefits of receiving Zakah or Khums.
3.6	Hajj as one of the Five Pillars: the nature, role, origins and significance of Hajj, including Surah 2:124–130 and 22:25–30; how Hajj is performed and why Hajj is important for Muslims; benefits and challenges of performing Hajj for Muslims.
3.7	Jihad: the origins, meaning and significance of Jihad in Islam; divergent understandings of Jihad within Islam, including the difference between lesser and greater Jihad; the conditions for declaration of lesser Jihad, including reference to Surah 2:190–194 and 22:39; the importance of Jihad in the life of Muslims.
3.8	The nature, origins, activities, meaning and significance of the celebration/commemoration of Id-ul-Adha, with reference to Surah 37:77–111, and Id-ul-Fitr in Sunni Islam, with reference to their place within Shi'a Islam; and Id-ul-Ghadeer, with reference to Hadith and the interpretation of Surah 5:3, and Ashura in Shi'a Islam, with reference to their place within Sunni Islam.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Muslim teaching on human rights: Muslim teachings and responses to the nature and purpose of human rights; why Muslims might support human rights as important, including Surah 5:8; divergent Muslim responses to the need for and application of individual human rights, including the support offered by situation ethics; the problems human rights might cause for Muslims; Muslim responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments about human rights.
4.2	Muslim attitudes towards equality: Muslim teachings and responses to the causes of inequality and problems caused by inequality in the world with reference to examples from the Hadith, including Sahih al-Bukhari 56:681; divergent Muslim teachings and practices that reflect equality; possible Islamic solutions to inequality and why Muslims may support them.
4.3	Muslim attitudes towards religious freedom: different Muslim teachings and responses to the nature and importance of religious freedom, including Surah 2:255–257; the divergent responses of Muslims to a multi-faith society; the benefits and challenges for Muslims living in a multi-faith society; Muslim responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) against aspects of religious freedom.
4.4	Muslim attitudes to prejudice and discrimination: Muslim teachings and responses to the nature of prejudice and discrimination, including Surah 49:13, and the problems they cause, including links to situation ethics; Muslim teachings on why prejudice and discrimination against religions is wrong.
4.5	Muslim attitudes towards racial harmony: Muslim teachings about racial harmony; different reasons and ways Muslims have worked for racial harmony, including teachings on racial harmony in the Final Sermon of Muhammad, and those that may reflect ethical theory; the benefits for Muslims of living in a multi-ethnic society.
4.6	Muslim teachings and attitudes towards racial discrimination: Muslim teachings about why it causes problems in society, including Surah 49:13; divergent Muslim responses to racial discrimination as shown in the life and teachings of Malcolm X.
4.7	Muslim attitudes to social justice: Muslim teachings and responses to and teachings about the nature of the distribution of wealth and opportunity in the UK and the world; Muslim teaching about social justice, including Surah 7:155–157; the different ways Muslims work for social justice; links to situation ethics and Muslim responses to them.
4.8	Muslim attitudes towards wealth and poverty: Muslim teachings and responses to the nature and causes of poverty in the UK and in the world; Muslim teachings about wealth and poverty, including Surah 2:177.

Area of Study 3D – Buddhism

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Buddhism as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about philosophy of religion and issues of equality and social justice.

There are four sections: Buddhist Beliefs, Philosophy of Religion, Living the Buddhist Life and Equality.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Buddhists today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how scripture informs a Buddhist's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Buddhism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Buddhism with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.5)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.6)*

Students should recognise that Buddhism is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Hinduism, Judaism, Islam, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Buddhism and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Buddhism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Buddhism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Theravada and Mahayana traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The life of the Buddha: the nature and history of the events in the life of the Buddha and why they are important to Buddhists today, including ancestry, birth, princely life, marriage and the Four Sights, with reference to Buddhavamsa XXVI; the enlightenment of the Buddha and founding of the Sangha.
1.2	Dhamma: the nature and different meaning of dhamma (dependent origination /conditionality); the nature and importance of paticca-samuppada and the Three Marks of Existence, including reference to the Story of Nagasena and the Chariot in the Milinda Panha; suffering (dukkha), no fixed self (anicca) and soul or essence (anatta); the implications of belief in dhamma for Buddhists today.
1.3	First Noble Truth, including reference to the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of dukkha; Buddhist teachings about suffering; the different types of suffering as pain, fabrication and change; the importance of suffering for Buddhists today.
1.4	Second Noble Truth, including reference to Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of samudaya (the root of suffering); Buddhist teachings about the causes of suffering, including the Sermon at Benares; the Three Poisons and how they are represented in the Wheel of Life; divergent understandings of the Wheel of Life, with reference to Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism.
1.5*	Third Noble Truth, including reference to the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of nirodha and the cessation of tanha; Buddhist teachings about the ending of desire; the nature of the cycle of samsara; different understandings of nibbana and enlightenment and their importance for Buddhists today.
1.6	Fourth Noble Truth, including reference to the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of the Middle Way (maggā); Buddhist teachings about the Eightfold Path leading to nibbana. The Threefold Way: the nature, purpose and importance of sila (ethics), samadhi (meditation) and panna (wisdom); divergent understandings of the importance Eightfold Path and the Threefold Way for Buddhist life today.
1.7	Human life: divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and importance of the Five Khandas (aggregates), including the Khandha Sutta; divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and importance of sunnata and tathagatagarbha (Buddha-nature); divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and importance of Arahant and Bodhisattva Ideals; divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and history of Buddhahood and the Pure Land.
1.8	Buddhist ethical teachings: divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature, purpose and importance of kamma, including Dhammapada 181–187 and the Khuddakapatha, merit and rebirth, karuna (compassion), metta (loving kindness), pancha sila (the Five Precepts) and the paramitas (Six Perfections); the divergent applications of each of these ethical teachings in Buddhist life today.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Buddhist teachings about the non-existence of a personal God: Buddha's teaching about the lack of need for God, including the Devadaha Sutta; the implications of lack of belief in a personal God for Buddhist life today.
2.2	Buddhist teachings about the Realm of Gods: Buddhist understanding of the devas and differences between a personal God and the devas, including the Śūraṅgama Sūtra Section 9 Chapter 11; the nature and symbolism of the Wheel of Life; the divergent attitudes toward the importance of the Wheel of Life for Buddhists today, including reference to Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism.
2.3	Enlightenment: Buddhist teachings about the nature of enlightenment in Theravada and Mahayana traditions; examples, including that of the Buddha in Maha-Saccaka Sutta; reasons why enlightenment might be regarded as important; the importance of enlightenment for Buddhists today; Buddhist responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that enlightenment is illogical and can be scientifically explained.
2.4	Buddhist teaching about miracles: divergent Buddhist teachings about the nature and importance of miracles, including the Buddha's attitude to the use of supernatural powers in the Kevatta Sutta and their use as a philosophical argument for the nature of reality; reasons why miracles might be important to Buddhists and why they might not, including reference to Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism; Buddhist responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that miracles can be scientifically explained.
2.5	Prayers: Buddhist teaching about the nature and importance of prayers; examples of prayers, including Avalokitesvara mantra (Om padme hum); reasons why Buddhists pray, including metta, sharing merit, opening the mind to consciousness; divergent Buddhist teachings why prayers might be important to Buddhists and why they might not be.
2.6	Visions: Buddhist teachings about the nature and importance of visions with reference to the Vajra Sutta and vision of Maitreya by Asanga and the giving of the 'Five Treatises of Maitreya'; Buddhist attitudes towards visions as emptiness/ illusions/ dreams as message dreams or as an indication of a person's mental health; divergent Buddhist teachings on why visions might be important to Buddhists and why they might not be; Buddhist responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that visions are hallucinations and provide no spiritual benefit.
2.7	Buddhist attitudes towards religious experiences, including reference to the Kevatta Sutta: Buddhist teachings and responses to the nature of a religious experience and its use as a philosophical argument for the nature of reality; divergent Buddhist teachings about whether religious experiences are real or provide religious knowledge; Buddhist responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments that religious experiences are not real.
2.8	Religious upbringing: how a Buddhist upbringing provides a basis for an understanding of reality; features of a Buddhist upbringing and why they may lead to belief, including the Sigalovada Sutta; Buddhist responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments about why a religious upbringing may result in a rejection of God's existence.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	Meditation: the nature, purpose and significance of meditation in Buddhism; the different types of meditation: samatha (concentration), metta bhavana (loving kindness) and vipassana (insight); meditative practices, including mindfulness breathing and zazen, divergent understanding of the nature and importance of visualisation of the Buddha and Bodhisattvas, including Amitāyus Meditation Sutra; how the different practices are used by Mahayana and Theravada Buddhists and the benefits from their use.
3.2	Chanting: the nature, purpose and role of chanting in Buddhism as a devotional practice and to gain mental concentration, including Dhammapada 1–2, confidence and joy. The divergent understandings of the importance of chanting in Buddhist life today: Theravada Buddhism, including Tiratana Buddhism, with reference to Dhammapada 190, and Mahayana Buddhism, including Nam Myoho Renge Kyo.
3.3	Mantra recitation: divergent understandings of the nature, purpose, role and importance of mantra recitation with reference to Theravada Buddhism, including Namo Buddhaya ('Homage to the Buddha'), and Mahayana Buddhism; the nature and purpose of using sacred syllables, devotional articles, offerings and mala beads and why they are used in different schools of Buddhism.
3.4	Features of Buddhist places of worship: the divergent nature, history and design of Buddhist places of worship, including temples, gompas, viharas, shrines in Theravada, Mahayana and Triratna Buddhism; how and why the places of worship are used, including reference to the shrine room, shrine facing east, and the library, showing the importance of learning with reference to the Kimsila Sutta.
3.5	How and why objects of devotion are used within different Buddhist places of worship, buddharupas, including reference to Vakkali Sutta, shrine, Bodhi tree; divergent understandings of why devotional objects are important in Buddhism today.
3.6*	Puja: the nature and purpose of puja in the vihara and the home, including reference to Mangala Sutta; examples of the different types; when each type might be used and why; the importance of having different types of worship and their use in different Buddhist contexts.
3.7	Death and mourning rituals and ceremonies: the divergent celebration and significance of the ceremonies in Buddhist communities and to Buddhists; the distinct significance of the rituals associated with death and mourning in Theravada communities and in Japan and Tibet, with reference to the Tibetan Book of the Dead.
3.8	Festivals and retreats: the divergent nature, history, purpose and importance of festivals and retreats in Buddhism; divergent understandings of the origins, meaning and features of celebration of specific festivals and retreats, including Wesak, Vassa/Rain Retreat and Kathina, with reference to the Anapanasati Sutta, and Uposatha days in Theravada Buddhism; Hanamatsuri and Obon (Japanese), Parinibbana Day in Mahayana Buddhism, and Lama Tsong Khapa Day in Tibet.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Buddhist teaching on human rights: Buddhist teachings and responses to the nature and purpose of human rights; why Buddhists might support human rights as important, including reference to upekkha and the Declaration of the International Network of Engaged Buddhists: Towards A Buddhist Culture of Non-Violence and Human Rights (May 1998); divergent Buddhist responses to the need for and application of individual human rights, including the support offered by situation ethics; the problems human rights might cause for Buddhists; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments about human rights and Buddhist responses to them.
4.2	Buddhist attitudes towards equality: Buddhist teachings and responses to the causes of inequality and problems caused by inequality in the world; divergent Buddhist teachings about and practices that reflect equality, including reference to Lotus Sutra 12; possible Buddhist solutions to inequality and why Buddhists may support them.
4.3	Buddhist attitudes towards religious freedom: different Buddhist teachings and responses to the nature and importance of religious freedom, including <i>Towards The True Kinship Of Faiths: How the World's Religions Can Come Together</i> Chapter 9 by the XIV Dalai Lama; the divergent responses of Buddhists to a multi-faith society; the benefits and challenges for Buddhists living in a multi-faith society; Buddhist responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) against aspects of religious freedom.
4.4	Buddhist attitudes to prejudice and discrimination: Buddhist teachings and responses to the nature of prejudice and discrimination, and the problems they cause, including links to situation ethics; Buddhist teachings on why prejudice and discrimination against religions is wrong, including Nipata Sutta.
4.5	Buddhist teachings about racial harmony; different reasons and ways Buddhists have worked for racial harmony, including Vaca Sutta and how these may link to situation ethics; the benefits for Buddhists of living in a multi-ethnic society.
4.6	Buddhist attitudes towards racial discrimination: Buddhist teachings about why it causes problems in society, including Dhammapada 129–140; Buddhist responses to racial discrimination as shown in the life and teachings of the XIV Dalai Lama.
4.7	Buddhist attitudes to social justice: divergent Buddhist responses to and teachings about the nature of the distribution of wealth and opportunity in the UK and the world; Buddhist teaching about social justice, including Sikshasamuccaya 280–281; the different ways Buddhists work for social justice; links to situation ethics.
4.8	Buddhist attitudes towards wealth and poverty: divergent Buddhist teachings and responses to the nature and causes of poverty in the UK and in the world; Buddhist teachings about wealth and poverty, including Cula Kammavibhanga Sutta, gaining merit and dana, and how these may link to situation ethics.